AUWA Business Plan

Source: Master Business Plan, March 2026. Updated April 2026 following strategic review. Maintained as living document.

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1. Executive Summary

AUWA is influenced by the ancient Japanese belief that a life force resides in all things. Mountains, rivers, handmade objects, animals, other people, and your own emotions: everything carries an essence worth noticing. The Japanese call this quality Kokoro (心): heart, soul, spirit. When you use something with care, over years and decades, it accumulates a kind of soul. In a culture of speed, distraction, and disposability, AUWA builds awareness: of how you feel, of the objects you live with, of the world you move through, and of your connection to the people and nature around you.

Where Western wellness centres on the self, AUWA draws from Japanese collectivist philosophy. Awareness isn't just inward. It extends outward: to the craftsman who spent decades mastering a single knife, to the micro-season shifting outside your window, to the stranger whose day you can change by paying attention. This is the philosophical foundation that connects everything AUWA does.

The thesis: In an age of acceleration and artificial intelligence, awareness is the human skill that matters most. The answers already exist in what previous generations practised and what modern life left behind. Japanese philosophy preserved them: the 72 micro-seasons, the craftsman traditions, the daily gratitude for all living things. AUWA brings these forward. With better awareness you make better choices, about what you consume, how you treat your environment, how you relate to others, and how you understand yourself.

The four pillars of the brand:

1. **Kokoro Mirror** (auwa.life/app) — A daily awareness practice. AI-powered emotional reflection that reveals your Kokoro through poetic language and Rieko's illustrated characters.
2. **AUWA Store** (auwa.life/store) — Curated Japanese craftsman marketplace. Lifetime products made by master artisans, shipped direct from Japan. Plus AUWA's own

collectible figures.

3. **AUWA Journal** (auwa.life/journal) — Editorial content. Travel stories, craftsman profiles, seasonal essays, onsen retreats. Photography-led, long-form, SEO-rich.
4. **AUWA Book** (auwa.life/book) — The illustrated story universe. A series of illustrated stories created over a decade by Rieko Maeda (artist name Eko), grounded in Japanese philosophy.

These are not four separate products — they're one world experienced through four doors. The app builds emotional awareness, the store cultivates material awareness (choosing intention over convenience, craft over disposability), the journal builds cultural awareness (seeing Japan through a philosophical lens, not a tourist one), and the book teaches philosophical awareness (seeing the Kokoro in all things through narrative).

Structural precedents: Kinfolk (aesthetic philosophy + editorial + experiences, acquired ~$30M), Monocle (worldview + editorial + retail + media, ~$10M+ revenue), Hodinkee (digital-age appreciation for craft, raised $40M+), Goop (wellness + curated retail + storytelling, ~$100M revenue), Snow Peak (gear + experiences + community, ¥25.7B). Multi-pillar lifestyle brands where each element reinforces the others. AUWA's unique angle: Japanese cultural authenticity rooted in a living philosophy, an illustrated story universe as foundation, and an AI-powered awareness practice as the daily touchpoint.

Opportunity in one sentence: AUWA is the first lifestyle brand to apply Japanese philosophical awareness — the understanding that everything has Kokoro — to modern life, through a daily practice, curated craft, editorial storytelling, and an illustrated universe rooted in centuries of Japanese wisdom.

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2. The Brand Philosophy

Since ancient times, the Japanese have believed that a life force resides in all things. Mountains, rivers, trees, animals, handmade objects, and even fleeting emotions: everything carries an essence worth noticing. There is no divide between the sacred and the ordinary, between thinking and feeling. Everything in the universe is interconnected. This worldview is expressed in concepts like Yaoyorozu no Kami (八百万の神, the "countless spirits" that populate the world) and in the folk belief that objects used with care, over years and decades, accumulate a kind of soul.

AUWA is influenced by this philosophy. Not as a marketing angle, but as a lived worldview: one that AUWA's creator grew up with in Kansai and that underpins a decade of her creative work.

AUWA uses the word Kokoro (心) as its own expression of this idea. Where English divides inner life into heart, mind, soul, and spirit, Kokoro holds them as a single, holistic whole: emotion, thought, and essence unified without division. It is the quality you sense in a handmade bowl, in a well-worn knife, in a season you almost didn't notice, in your own emotions when you stop long enough to feel them.

What This Philosophy Means in Practice

At the brand level, it means awareness. Awareness that the knife on your counter was made by hands that spent forty years perfecting a single craft. Awareness that the season outside your window shifted five days ago and you didn't notice. Awareness that the person sitting next to you on the train is carrying something heavy. Awareness that your own emotions, even the difficult ones, carry meaning and deserve to be witnessed rather than fixed.

This is the opposite of the Western wellness model, which centres on the self. Japanese collectivist philosophy starts from connection: you are not the centre, you are part of a whole. The reason Japan's streets are clean, its temples preserved, its service culture extraordinary is not rules. It's awareness. Awareness of others. Awareness of shared space. Awareness that your actions ripple outward.

In an era where efficiency and economics became the top priority, much of this was lost. But as Matsuba Tomi, who runs a folk house inn in Japan, puts it: "If we reexamine the inefficient, the values of the past, we can have a better way of life." AUWA exists to do exactly that: to bring forward what Japanese philosophy preserved, and to show that even if you can't live this way all the time, it can be a model, informing the choices you make and slowly changing things for the better.

Today, with record tourism (42.7M visitors in 2025), Japan is experiencing the tension of this philosophy colliding with cultures that lack it. AUWA doesn't lecture about this. It builds the awareness that makes lectures unnecessary. When you sense the life force in a 400-year-old temple, you don't need a sign telling you not to vandalise it. When you see the person next to you as connected to you, you behave differently. This is gentle education through philosophy, not rules.

When you see the Kokoro in a ceramic cup, a forest, a stranger's face, your own sadness, you make more conscious choices. About what you consume. How you travel. How you treat your environment. How you relate to others.

How the Philosophy Powers Each Pillar

The App builds emotional awareness. Through a daily practice of sharing how you feel, AUWA's AI reflects your Kokoro back through poetic language and Rieko's illustrated characters. Not just your emotions, but the holistic state of your inner life: feeling, thought, and spirit as one. Over time, you develop deeper self-perception. The app uses a proprietary emotional framework based on Yamato language (ancient Japanese) to identify and reflect nuanced feelings, though users never see the taxonomy.

The Store cultivates material awareness. Every object is chosen because a craftsman poured their Kokoro into making it. Buying a hand-forged knife or a ceramic tea cup from a master artisan is a conscious act — choosing intention over convenience, craft over disposability, Kokoro over commodity.

The Journal builds cultural awareness. Travel stories, craftsman profiles, and seasonal essays that share Japan through AUWA's philosophical lens — written by Tom and Rieko from over 15 years of travelling Japan together. Not tourist itineraries but atmospheric writing about onsen culture, temple mornings, rural craft towns, the changing seasons. The journal naturally models how to engage with Japan respectfully: with curiosity, patience, and an understanding that you are a guest in someone else's home. Photography-led, contemplative, grounded.

The Book teaches philosophical awareness. A series of illustrated stories show the AUWA character revealing the Kokoro in a flower, a coral, a displaced tanuki, a human. The narrative makes the abstract philosophy concrete and felt — the best way to understand Yaoyorozu no Kami is to see it embodied in story.

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3. Massive Transformative Purpose, Vision, Mission & Values

MTP: To show the world that a more aware, more intentional life is possible, guided by Japanese philosophy that has practised it for centuries.

Short form (internal): *Restore awareness to a distracted world.* (Robin Sharma)

Vision: A world where people live with deeper awareness: of their emotions, of the objects they share their lives with, of the natural world around them, and of their connection to other people. A world where that awareness leads to a more intentional, purposeful life: what the Japanese call ikigai. Real abundance is not material. It is the abundance of the heart.

Mission: To apply Japanese philosophical awareness to modern life, expressed through four interconnected things: a daily awareness practice, curated craftsman objects, editorial

storytelling, and an illustrated story universe, all rooted in the ancient Japanese belief that a life force resides in all things.

Public framing on auwa.life uses "AUWA expresses this through four things" and "four ways in" as the customer-facing language for how the pillars relate to the philosophy. "Expressions" is the internal frame for how the four pillars sit in relation to the philosophy — not separate products, but one philosophy made visible four ways.

Core Values:

- Awareness over autopilot: notice more, consume less, choose better
- Kokoro over commerce: soul precedes sales in every decision
- Connection over individualism: you are part of a whole, not the centre of it
- Depth over surface: history and imperfection carry more beauty than polish. Old things made with care, made with the soul, are the most beautiful
- Respect over consumption: engage with culture, craft, and places as a guest, not a customer
- Authenticity over algorithm: cultural truth and 15+ years of shared experience in Japan are the moat
- Seasonal wisdom over hustle culture: honour cycles, not streaks
- Clarity over clutter

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4. The AUWA Name & Origin

The name AUWA (あうわ) derives from Woshite cosmology, one of the oldest streams of Japanese philosophical thought. あ (A) represents the heavens and the unseen, う (U) represents the connection between worlds, わ (WA) represents the earth and the seen. AUWA means "the harmony between the unseen and the seen" — making the invisible visible.

This etymology encodes what the brand does: making invisible things visible. The app makes invisible emotions visible. The store reveals the invisible craftsmanship within everyday objects. The journal makes the invisible world of Japan visible through atmospheric storytelling. The book makes the invisible Kokoro within all living things visible through illustrated narrative.

Within the book and app, AUWA is also a character — a luminous being who reveals the Kokoro in everything through a magical light shower. The character is the embodiment of the philosophy, not a mascot. It appears only in the stories and the app, making those spaces feel special. The broader brand — the store, the journal, the overall identity — expresses the

philosophy through design, editorial, and craft without needing the character. Think of it like Studio Ghibli: deep cosmological philosophy underpins every film, but the marketing is just beautiful imagery and a feeling. The depth is there for those who go looking.

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6. Products & Services

6.1 Kokoro Mirror App (auwa.life/app) - Year 1 Priority

A daily awareness practice. Five minutes. The user shares how they feel, AUWA's AI identifies the emotion and reflects it back poetically alongside Rieko's illustrated AUWA character, a light shower animation, and a calligraphic stamp. The result is saved to a visual archive and optionally journaled and shared. No streaks, no badges, no push notifications. AUWA is pull, not push. **AUWA does not fix. AUWA reveals.**

The AUWA character appears in the app — this is one of the two spaces (alongside the book) where the character lives as a presence, giving the practice warmth and distinctiveness.

Emotional Framework: The app uses a proprietary framework based on Yamato language (ancient Japanese) to identify and reflect nuanced emotional states. Five core states — Hare (晴/Radiant), Takaburi (昂/Intense), Aware (哀/Reflective), Yuragi (揺/Unsettled), and Nagomi (和/Serene) — each containing multiple sub-expressions described through poetic Japanese words. This replaces the earlier Kido Airaku framework with something richer and more nuanced. Users never see the taxonomy; they feel the precision.

The 72 Micro-Seasons: Japan's 72 micro-seasons (Shichijūni-kō) divide the year into five-day periods reflecting subtle natural changes. In the app, they appear as an ambient calligraphic stamp on the revelation screen — atmospheric, tappable for the curious. The AI's reflections do NOT force connections to the current micro-season. The micro-seasons also power the content calendar (72 posts/year, refreshing every 5 days).

Why EQ matters (app-specific evidence):

- Demand for emotional and social skills projected to grow ~26% by 2030
- WEF Future of Jobs Report 2025 identifies EQ among top core skills alongside technological literacy
- Frontiers in Psychology 2025: documented a global decline of nearly 6% in EQ scores between 2019 and 2024

- Capgemini: 83% of organisations say highly emotionally intelligent workforce will be a prerequisite for success

The daily practice of noticing and naming your emotions — the core of the Kokoro Mirror — trains all four pillars of EQ (Salovey & Mayer): perceiving emotions (Kokoro revelation), using emotions (journal reflection), understanding emotions (Kokoro Archive pattern recognition), and managing emotions (the natural result of sustained awareness practice).

User Experience Flow:

1. **Arrival** — Dark, calm screen. Soft glowing orb pulses. "How are you feeling right now?" Up to 200 words. No signup wall.
2. **Light Shower** — Orb brightens. Aurora-coloured light cascades 3-5 seconds. Subtle atmospheric audio.
3. **Kokoro Revelation** — Gradient background (colour families mapped to emotional states), AUWA character variant (hand-illustrated by Rieko), calligraphic kō stamp. AI-generated poetic reflection below.
4. **Journal Prompt** — Smart pre-population or open prompt. Optional.
5. **Share** — Designed card for Instagram Stories (9:16) and square. Journal entry always private.
6. **Save** — Auto-saved to Kokoro Archive.
7. **Returning Users** — "AUWA remembers you. Your last visit, you carried [emotion]."
8. **Story Unlocks** — 5th revelation: Story 1. 15th: Story 2. And so on.

What the user never sees: Emotional taxonomy, framework names, micro-season names forced into reflections, advice, diagnosis, streaks.

Technical Architecture:

- Pre-designed visual assets (not AI-generated images): character variants, gradient families, calligraphic stamps
- AI generates only text via Claude API
- Claude Haiku 4.5 as default (~~£0.002/revelation). Sonnet 4.5 as ceiling (~~£0.008-0.015/revelation)
- Even at Sonnet with 2,000 DAU: £600/month API vs £14,000/month subscription revenue

Data:

- Editorial content (emotions, seasons, lore, stories): Sanity CMS
- User data (accounts, check-ins, journal, archive): Vercel Postgres

Tech Stack: Next.js (TypeScript), Vercel, Sanity CMS, Vercel Postgres, Claude API, Framer Motion, Resend, Stripe

Pricing (Freemium):

- Free: 3 revelations/month
- Paid: £6.99/month or £49.99/year (unlimited revelations, full archive, pattern insights, journal, story unlocks, shareable cards, early figure access)

6.2 AUWA Store (auwa.life/store) - Year 1 Soft Launch

A curated multi-merchant marketplace for Japanese craftsman products, plus AUWA's own collectible figures. Positioned as "lifetime products with Kokoro" — the antithesis of throwaway culture. In the same way Hodinkee proved that a digital-age audience would develop deep appreciation for hand-crafted mechanical watches, AUWA bets that AI acceleration makes people more hungry for objects made by human hands with centuries of tradition behind them.

Concept: Japanese master craftsmen sell through the AUWA platform. Merchants manage their own products, orders, and shipping from Japan. AUWA provides the brand, curation, audience, and premium presentation. Tom's experience running a Japanese multi-merchant platform (2005-2007) is the direct precedent: standardised premium imagery, automated currency conversion, and direct-from-Japan shipping. The Monolise project (designed by More Air for a Japanese craft store connecting local craftspeople with global buyers) provides additional design and operational insight — minimal presentation that lets the products speak, Shopify-based, anti-throwaway culture positioning.

What's on the store:

- **Shokunin Treasures:** Curated Japanese craft — knives, ceramics, tea caddies, washi goods, textiles. Hand-made, lifetime quality. £80-500+. Each product includes craftsman story and photography.
- **AUWA Figures:** Limited-edition collectible figures representing AUWA's emotional states. 3D-printed in-house (BambuLab X1 Carbon), eco-friendly materials, hand-finished, numbered, signed by Rieko. 12-15cm, £120-180. Certificate of authenticity + story booklet.

Tech stack: Shopify with Multi-Vendor Marketplace app (Webkul or equivalent). Stripe Connect for direct merchant payouts to Japan. Shopify Duty & Import Taxes for transparent landed-cost pricing at checkout. AI-assisted image standardisation (consistent white backgrounds, premium presentation across all merchants).

Merchant onboarding: Rieko leads outreach in Japanese. Initial target: 5-10 craftsmen from existing Monolise relationships and new contacts. Merchants upload products in Japanese; AUWA handles translation, image polish, and Western-facing presentation.

Timeline: Teaser page live from Week 1. First craftsman products Month 6-9 (after app validates). AUWA figures can launch earlier (Month 4-6) as they're self-produced.

Figure success metrics: 70%+ sell-through within 4 weeks. If <30%: pause figures.

6.3 AUWA Journal (auwa.life/journal) - Year 1 Editorial

Long-form editorial content that builds brand authority, drives organic search traffic, and gives the audience a reason to return between app sessions. Photography-led, atmospheric, written in the AUWA voice.

Content types:

- **Travel stories:** Japan through AUWA's lens — not itineraries, but atmospheric essays. Onsen culture, temple mornings, rural craft towns, seasonal landscapes. Tom's photography (17M+ Unsplash views, published in Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, Travel + Leisure) provides the visual foundation.
- **Craftsman profiles:** The makers behind the store. Workshop visits, process photography, the philosophy of a lifetime object. Bridges directly to store products.
- **Seasonal essays:** Tied to the 72 micro-seasons content calendar. Short, contemplative pieces on noticing change.
- **Behind the Kokoro:** Rieko's illustration process, AUWA's creative development, the philosophy in practice.

Production workflow: Tom provides photo folders + title + bullet points. Claude writes the article in AUWA's voice. Rieko reviews for cultural accuracy. Future: video content from craftsman visits (ASMR-style making films).

SEO value: Each article targets long-tail keywords the brand naturally owns — Japanese craft, emotional intelligence, seasonal living, specific artisan traditions. This is the content layer that makes auwa.life discoverable beyond social media.

Tech: Sanity CMS. Same Next.js codebase as the main site. Markdown-friendly for fast publishing.

6.4 AUWA Book (auwa.life/book) - Year 1 Brand Home

The canonical home of the AUWA universe and the illustrated stories. Hub linking all four pillars. This is where the deeper mythology lives — the WAWA origin, the character's story, the philosophy in narrative form.

The AUWA Universe: AUWA originates from WAWA, a harmonious solar system deep within the Milky Way. When its inhabitants received a mysterious signal from Earth, they channelled energy to form a glowing orb of pure light. From this orb emerged AUWA — a being whose magical light shower reveals the Kokoro within every living creature. AUWA communicates through telepathy: gentle, observant, non-judgmental. This mythology enriches the stories and gives depth to the app, but it lives here — in the book section — not in brand communications. The Monocle reader encounters philosophy and craft; those who go deeper find a cosmic story.

The Series of Illustrated Stories (2015-2025): Created by Rieko Maeda over a decade of development. Never published. Being prepared for digital release as illustrated art stories, with limited-edition physical versions to follow. Released over time within the app as narrative segments unlocked through continued engagement.

1. **The Beginning** — AUWA arrives on Earth, discovers a quiet forest where a lonely blue flower (Bluu) shares memories of a diminished ecosystem. Light shower reveals Kokoro within flower and surrounding microbes.
2. **Umi (Ocean)** — AUWA explores beneath the waves, meeting Key the coral, Lady the fish, and Rai the turtle. Ocean damaged by pollution. AUWA's light restores the sea and leads to the ancient Coral Paradise.
3. **Human** — AUWA encounters Rappon the tanuki (displaced from a changing forest) and Kazu (a human who left city life to live in harmony with nature). Interconnection between human activity, animal displacement, and environmental change.
4. **Lioma** — AUWA takes human Kokoro to Planet Lioma in the WAWA system, where the Maon beings live in harmony through telepathic communication.

Stories originally written in Japanese. Limited-edition physical printed versions in Year 2.

Content also includes: Brand story and AUWA etymology, Yaoyorozu no Kami philosophy, creator bios, links to app, store, and journal.

6.5 Seasonal Journeys (Year 1 Prototype, see `arrival.md`)

Small, once-a-year guided Japan experiences for foreigners to meet craftsmen and visit places not otherwise accessible. Five people, four to six days. Constrained to one trip per year by the founders' UK life (dog) and by the quality bar. Prototype Autumn 2026 or Spring 2027. At £3-4K per person, a single trip generates £15-20K at healthy margin and produces a year's worth of

editorial content. Why this matters: the journal is *about* hidden experiences; the journey *is* that experience; the store sells the craftsmen's objects; the app builds daily awareness. The journey is what binds the pillars into something lived. Interest gathering begins immediately via soft CTAs at the foot of relevant journal articles and a dedicated Resend segment. See `arrival.md` for full plan.

6.6 Year 2+ Vision (Earned by Year 1 Results)

- London pop-up workshops (kintsugi, ikebana, EQ classes)
- Hotel Digital EQ Experience (B2B) - white-label for luxury hotels
- White-Label EQ Platform (B2B) - hospitals, neurodiversity clinics, corporate wellness, education
- AUWA lifestyle products (journal, merch, curated boxes)
- Ukiyo-e Print Series: "72 Seasons of AUWA"
- Physical Printed Stories + Digital Art Releases
- Exhibition: "AUWA Revealed"
- EQ corporate programmes (app + workshops)
- Patreon-style community tier (or built into app)

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7. Market

Market landscape: AUWA sits at the intersection of several growing markets: AI wellness (~$9.45B in 2026, projected $18B by 2031), Japanese cultural exports (anime market $37.7B, tourism 42.7M visitors in 2025), the premium craft/design economy, and the broader lifestyle editorial space. No single market size captures AUWA because no brand currently assembles all these elements under one roof.

Target audience: Design-conscious, culturally curious people drawn to Japanese aesthetics, philosophy, and craft. They value meaning over metrics, intention over convenience, and quality over quantity. They read Kinfolk and Monocle, appreciate Aesop's retail experience, follow Studio Ghibli, and are more likely to buy one handmade knife than a drawer full of disposable ones. They are underserved by Headspace (too clinical), generic wellness apps (lack cultural depth), and most "self-help" products (too prescriptive). AUWA's different pillars attract different entry points within this audience — some arrive through the journal and photography, others through the app, others through the store — but all share the same sensibility.

Uncopyable advantages ("The Authenticity Moat"):

- Rieko's decade of creation + a series of completed illustrated stories
- Japanese cultural authenticity (Kansai-born, Japanese-educated, native Japanese speaker)
- Yaoyorozu no Kami embedded by a Japanese creator who grew up within the philosophy
- Proprietary emotional framework based on Yamato language
- 72 micro-seasons as perpetual content rhythm (refreshing every 5 days)
- Hand-illustrated character variants
- Physical craft layer + direct Japanese craftsman relationships
- Editorial depth (Tom's published Japan photography, 17M+ Unsplash views)
- Four interconnected pillars that reinforce each other — no competitor has more than one

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8. Go-To-Market Strategy

The Sequence: Brand First, Products Second

The website establishes the brand. Instagram builds the audience. The app and store launch into an audience that already understands what AUWA is. This is the opposite of building in a vacuum and hoping people find you.

The core website (auwa.life) comes first. A beautiful, Kinfolk-inspired hub that introduces the brand philosophy, houses the journal, teases the app and store, and gives Instagram posts somewhere to point to. Typography-led, photography-rich, serene. This is the brand's home — the thing that makes AUWA feel real and credible before a single product ships. Built with Claude Code in a few focused days using the existing Next.js foundation.

Social Strategy: Instagram First

Single-platform focus until 5K followers. Instagram is where the audience lives — design-conscious, Japan-interested, culturally curious. TikTok skews younger and more fleeting. YouTube is for depth content later. One strong Instagram account looks intentional; scattered small accounts look amateur. Expand to TikTok reposts and YouTube after 5K.

See `context/instagram.md` for detailed IG strategy, specs, content pillars, and growth plan.

Phase 1: Brand Foundation (Weeks 1-6)

Parallel tracks:

- **Core website:** Build auwa.life — brand home, journal section with first editorial pieces, app teaser, store teaser, email capture. Kinfolk-level design quality. Typography-forward, photography-rich, dark aesthetic.
- **Instagram:** Daily posting from vault content (Japan photography, Rieko's illustrations, AUWA animations, Fin DAC stencil session). Target: 700 → 2,000+ followers.
- **First journal articles:** 3-5 editorial pieces using existing Japan photography. Atmospheric travel essays, seasonal reflections. Start building SEO presence.
- **Creative direction:** Lock illustration refresh, character variants, brand feel.

Success metrics (Week 6): Website live and beautiful. 3+ journal articles published. 1,000+ IG followers. 200+ email signups. Brand feels coherent and premium across website and social.

Phase 2: Build + Launch App (Weeks 6-16)

- **App build:** Kokoro Mirror MVP via Claude Code. Character variants, AI integration, light shower, archive, journal, shareable cards, freemium.
- **Instagram continues:** Paid promotion £15-25/day on best-performing Reels. Target: 2,000-3,000+ followers.
- **Journal continues:** New articles fortnightly. SEO begins compounding.
- **Soft launch app** to waitlist. First 100-200 signups get beta access.

Success metrics (Week 16): 50+ active app users, 60%+ completion rate, 5+ paid conversions, shareable cards posted organically, 3,000+ IG followers.

Decision gate:

- 50+ active, 60%+ completion, paid conversions: Proceed to Phase 3
- 20-49 users, 40-59% completion: Iterate app, keep building audience
- <20 users, <40% completion: Major reassessment of app approach

Phase 3: Store Soft Launch (Months 6-12)

Begin craftsman outreach — Rieko contacts initial merchants in Japanese. First craftsman products on auwa.life/store. Craftsman profiles in journal feed directly into store. Begin YouTube channel (craftsman making videos, Japan travel, philosophy deep-dives). Expand sub-expression nuance in app. Activate story unlocks. Press/podcast outreach (after 5K IG followers). Fin DAC collaboration.

Phase 4: Scale (Year 2)

Earned by results. First AUWA figure drop (self-produced, 3D-printed). Retreats, workshops, hotel B2B, exhibition, expanded store.

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9. Content Engine

Instagram content pillars:

1. **Kokoro Reveal** — AUWA illustrations paired with poetic reflections. The signature format. Shareable, beautiful, brand-building.
2. **Seasonal Living** — Japan photography tied to the rhythm of the year. Atmospheric, contemplative. Bridges to journal articles.
3. **Behind the Kokoro** — Rieko's illustration process, craftsman workshops, creative decisions. Human, process-driven.
4. **Japanese Wisdom** — Philosophy in practice. Micro-seasons, awareness concepts, quotes. Carousels and Reels.

72 micro-seasons calendar provides an always-on content rhythm refreshing every 5 days. Posts on Instagram 4-5 times per week.

Existing content vault (ready to deploy): 15+ years of Japan photography (Tom's Japan photography has amassed 17M+ views on Unsplash and been used by Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, World Economic Forum, Travel + Leisure, TimeOut, and Culture Trip), Rieko's illustrations and animations, Fin DAC AUWA stencil session, craftsman photography from Monolise research trips, AUWA story scenes (10+ polished scenes usable now).

YouTube (Phase 2-3): Long-form craftsman videos (ASMR-style making processes), Japan travel content, philosophy deep-dives, interviews. Bi-weekly uploads once established.

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10. Customer Acquisition

Channels

- **Organic Instagram:** The primary growth engine. 72 micro-seasons content rhythm, illustration reveals, Japan photography, craftsman spotlights, AUWA animation Reels. Shareable Kokoro cards from the app as a zero-cost viral mechanic.

- **Paid Instagram (£2,000 Year 1):** £15-25/day in bursts on best-performing Reels. Split: 60% follower growth/awareness, 30% email capture/waitlist, 10% retargeting. Expected: 1,500-3,000 quality followers + 300-800 email signups.
- **SEO via Journal:** In 2026, traditional search has evolved — Google's AI Overviews now summarise results directly, reducing click-through for generic queries. But long-tail, specific, expertise-driven content still drives organic traffic. AUWA's journal articles target keywords the brand naturally owns: specific Japanese crafts, artisan traditions, onsen culture, seasonal philosophy, Japan travel through a philosophical lens. These are niche topics where genuine experience (Tom's 15+ years of Japan photography, Rieko's cultural authenticity) signals authority that AI search tools (Google, Perplexity, ChatGPT) surface and cite. Each article serves dual purposes: brand depth for existing audience + discovery for new visitors. SEO compounds over time — articles published in Month 1 are still driving traffic in Month 12.
- **Collaborations:** Fin DAC (96K IG followers, existing AUWA stencil — warm lead). Japanese culture accounts, illustration accounts, design/philosophy accounts via Instagram's native collab post feature.
- **Podcast/press outreach (after 5K IG):** Wellness, Japan culture, design podcasts. Press: Dezeen, It's Nice That, Monocle, The Verge.

Year 1 marketing budget: ~£3,000-4,000 (Instagram-focused spend is more efficient than multi-platform).

Conversion Model (by Month 12)

Metric	Conservative	Expected	Optimistic
Monthly new users (free app)	100	250	500
Free-to-paid conversion	2%	3%	5%
Paid app subscribers	~25	~90	~300
Monthly journal visitors (SEO)	500	2,000	5,000
Email list	300	800	2,000

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11. Revenue Model & Financial Projections

AUWA generates revenue across all four pillars. More Air client work funds founders separately — AUWA revenue is reinvested into growth.

Revenue Streams by Pillar

App (auwa.life/app): Freemium subscriptions. Free tier (3 revelations/month) drives trial; paid tier (£6.99/month or £49.99/year) unlocks unlimited use, archive insights, story content, shareable cards.

Store (auwa.life/store): Two streams. (1) Commission on craftsman products sold through the marketplace (15-25% depending on category and merchant). (2) Direct revenue from AUWA's own collectible figures (self-produced, high margin). Tom's operational precedent: a niche Japanese vinyl figure store in 2004-2007 generated ~£1,500/month profit — with a fraction of the audience and tools available today.

Journal (auwa.life/journal): Not a direct revenue stream in Year 1 — its value is brand building, SEO traffic, and audience development that feeds the other three pillars. Future potential: sponsored content from aligned brands, affiliate partnerships with featured craftsmen, premium subscriber-only articles.

Book (auwa.life/book): Story content unlocked through paid app tier. Future: limited-edition physical printed versions, digital art releases.

Year 1 Revenue

Stream	Conservative	Expected	Optimistic
App Subscriptions	£1,000	£3,500	£12,000
Store — Craftsman Commission (Month 6+)	£0	£3,000	£9,000
AUWA Total	**£1,000**	**£6,500**	**£21,000**

Year 1 is conservative by design: the website and journal launch first, the app follows, the store comes last. No figure drops in Year 1 (moved to Year 2 when audience is established).

Costs

Monthly: £660-1,065 (API, hosting, tools, marketing, virtual office). One-time: £4,290-5,290 (trademark, figure production, seeding, domains). Year 1 total: ~£12,000-18,000.

Year 1 Summary

Scenario	Revenue	Costs	Net
Conservative	£1,000	£14,000	-£13,000
Expected	£6,500	£16,000	-£9,500
Optimistic	£21,000	£18,000	+£3,000

Year 1 is an investment year funded by More Air client work. Self-sustaining threshold: ~100-150 paid app subscribers + modest store sales covers monthly operating costs.

Year 2 (Contingent on Traction)

Stream	Target
App Subscriptions (500-2,000 paid)	£42,000-168,000
Store — Craftsman Commission (full catalogue)	£18,000-60,000
Store — AUWA Figures (2-4 drops)	£15,000-45,000
Journal — Affiliate/Sponsored (if validated)	£2,000-10,000
Hotel B2B (first deal)	£25,000-75,000
Retreats/workshops (if validated)	£5,000-20,000
Year 2 Range	**£107,000-378,000**

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12. Corporate & Legal Structure

> Full details in `context/structure.md` (AUWA-Business-Structure.pdf). Summary below.

AUWA Limited (Co. 17033727) owns all IP. Dormant. Rieko + Tom 50/50. Licenses to More Air. **More Air Limited** (Co. 7051794) operates AUWA. Active since 2009. Receives revenue, pays expenses.

Trademarks (UK IPO):

- Word mark "AUWA": UK00004341028 (Classes 9, 16, 20, 41, in advertisement phase) + UK00004373944 (Classes 25, 28, 35, filed 16 April 2026)
- Design mark (AUWA character): UK00004373930 (Classes 20, 28, filed 16 April 2026)
- International (Madrid Protocol): Japan, USA, EU planned by August 2026

Domains: auwa.life (primary), auwa.app, auwa.world, auwa.store + .com equivalents. 11 domains total. **Social:** @auwalife across most platforms, @auwa.life on TikTok and Bluesky, @auwa on LinkedIn. See `context/social.md` for the full account map. **Email:** hello@auwa.life

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13. Team

The Creator + Producer Model

Following the traditional Japanese ukiyo-e model (artist + publisher as equal partnership). Tsutaya Juzaburo is the historical precedent.

Rieko Maeda, Creator (Eshi): Japanese-born illustrator from Kansai, also known by her artist name Eko. Creator of the AUWA universe (2015-2025). Native Japanese speaker. 20+ years design and illustration. (Legal name: Rieko Vining.) Year 1: 4 AUWA character variants, seasonal content (social + copy + audio in Suno), figure design, creative direction.

Tom Vining, Producer (Hanmoto): Design technologist and brand strategist. 20+ years experience (Nokia, Apple, Sky). Built and operated a Japanese multi-merchant platform (2005-2007) selling Japanese design objects to Western buyers — including distributing KAWS's first international releases. Published photographer whose Japan work has 17M+ views on Unsplash and has been used by Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, World Economic Forum, Travel + Leisure, TimeOut, and Culture Trip. Expert in AI-native workflows. Year 1: App design and build, brand, business development, financials, marketing, project oversight.

Capacity: Tuesday-Friday (3-4 day week, 10am-6pm). AUWA gets 60%, More Air 25%, ventures 10%. Shifts toward AUWA as revenue grows. No work Monday.

AI tools: Claude, Cursor, Suno, v0. Learning curve built into timeline.

Project Management: Notion. Weekly rhythm. Simple Kanban. Fortnightly reviews.

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14. Risk Analysis

Risk	Pillar	Likelihood	Mitigation
Brand doesn't resonate / no audience builds	All	Medium	Website + journal + IG validate brand appeal before products launch. Client work funds experimentation.
App doesn't resonate	App	Medium	Soft launch to waitlist. <20 users = reassess approach, not the brand.
AI reflection quality insufficient	App	High	Single most important deliverable. Disproportionate time on prompt engineering.
AI apps commoditised	App	High	Cultural depth + Yaoyorozu no Kami + proprietary emotional framework + Rieko's art = uncopyable.
Craftsman onboarding is slow	Store	Medium	Start with Monolise relationships. Rieko's native Japanese is critical. Small catalogue is fine — curation over volume.
Store logistics (Japan → global)	Store	Medium	Tom's 2005-2007 operational precedent. Merchants handle shipping. Shopify Duty & Import Taxes for transparency.
Figures don't sell	Store	Medium	Pre-orders + giveaway seeding. <30% sell-through = pause physical. Deferred to Year 2 to reduce Year 1 risk.
Journal content doesn't drive traffic	Journal	Medium	SEO compounds over time. Even modest traffic builds authority for partnerships. Low cost to maintain.
API costs increase	App	Low	Pre-designed visuals keep costs marginal. 5x increase still viable.
Client work crowds out AUWA	All	Medium	Minimum 10 hours/week for AUWA. Decision gates at milestones.
No one discovers AUWA	All	High	Multi-channel: IG paid + organic, SEO via journal, shareable cards, collaborations, press.
New to shipping software	App	High	Extra time built in. MVP not finished product. Iterate from feedback.

15. Strategic Priorities (Next 12 Weeks)

1. **Lock creative direction (Weeks 1-2):** Illustration refresh, character variants, font decision, colour system finalised. Brand feel locked before building anything.
2. **Build core website — auwa.life (Weeks 1-3):** Brand home, journal section, app teaser, store teaser, email capture. Kinfolk-level design quality. Built with Claude Code on the existing Next.js foundation. A few focused days, not weeks.
3. **Build Instagram audience (Weeks 1-12, continuous):** Instagram only. Daily posting from vault content. Paid promotion from Week 5. Target: 700 → 2,000-3,000 followers.
4. **Publish first journal articles (Weeks 2-4):** 3-5 editorial pieces using existing Japan photography. Start building SEO presence and brand depth.
5. **Build Kokoro Mirror MVP (Weeks 4-12):** Character variants, AI integration, light shower, archive, journal, shareable cards, freemium. AI reflection quality is the single most important deliverable.
6. **Store preparation (Weeks 8-12):** Craftsman pitch deck. Rieko outreach to initial merchants. Shopify setup.

App soft launch at Week 12-16. Store soft launch Month 6-9. Figures and YouTube are Year 2.

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16. Future Vision

As AI accelerates and automates more of life's cognitive tasks, the human layer that matters most is awareness — of how you feel, what you value, how your choices affect the world around you, and how you connect with other people. AUWA is designed for this future.

The brand scales across all four pillars. The journal becomes a respected editorial voice in the Japanese culture/design space. The store becomes the definitive destination for curated Japanese craft in the West. The app becomes the daily awareness practice that millions use. The book becomes the illustrated philosophy that underpins it all. Each pillar reinforces the others — journal readers discover the store, app users share cards that drive new visitors, store customers subscribe to the journal.

The agentic web. In a future where AI agents handle most routine tasks, AUWA becomes the culturally-rich interface that understands not just what you want done, but how you feel about it

— and helps you make more conscious choices about what to buy, how to live, and how to relate to the world. 3-5 year vision, not Year 1 scope.

Key Contacts

- Tom Vining, Producer: tom@moreair.co
- Rieko Maeda, Creator: rieko@moreair.co
- AUWA: auwa.life (auwalife.com mirror)
- More Air: moreair.co
- Contact: hello@auwa.life
- Social: @auwalife (most platforms) | @auwa.life (TikTok, Bluesky) | @auwa (LinkedIn) — see `context/social.md`
- Companies House: AUWA Ltd 17033727 | More Air Ltd 7051794
- Trademarks: UK00004341028 (word mark, advertisement phase) | UK00004373944 (word mark, filed) | UK00004373930 (design mark, filed)

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